

[Return to Search](#)

## Marriage among the Nkundu

**Author(S):** Hulstaert, Gustave E., Vizedom, Monika B.

**Document Type:** Book

**Original Page:** 93

**Culture (OWC):** [Mongo \(F032\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Central Africa

**Field Date:** Ca. 1930

**Coverage Date:** 1930-1939

**Place Coverage:** Congo, Congo Basin

**Section Title(S):** Part 3 The Search For A Wife

### Part 3 The Search for a Wife

When a young man old enough to marry believes he has the means to do so, he goes out to seek a wife. Naturally, he knows a number of girls, and as a rule he has no trouble finding one who suits him. The courtship is quite simple. As everywhere there are meetings, visits, chats, and jokes; but there is no romanticism or sentimentality, for they are absolutely unknown to these peoples. Since they are in a hurry to reach the objective of their relationship, namely conjugal life, — and their progress toward this goal is facilitated by usages and customs — there remains little time for poetry.

584  
[Arranging A Marriage](#)

831  
[Sexuality](#)

There is no specific term for courtship itself. The Nkundó simply speak of "talking with a woman," sooja b'omoto, "looking for a woman," asa b'omoto. The girl who is its object is referred to as bombóyó (or boambá among the Injóló).

584  
[Arranging A Marriage](#)

First, the young man addresses his proposals to the girl: "ndanga ñkokolé (ñkokumbóle) la w'ali," "I want to take you for wife." She shows her agreement by saying, "ñkolanga wě ng ́ókó," I love, you also, "or more frequently," elaká ô w' , "as you wish," j'oi ô l'ikě, "it's up to you," or something of this sort. (1)

195  
Sociolinguistics

576  
Etiquette

584  
Arranging A Marriage

The lovers exchange gifts. The girl gives food which her mother has provided, or which she has been able to procure herself. 94 For his part, the young man gives her some small game animals (especially the big rat called botómba, lemurs of the genus eséndé, etc.) or fish. These gifts have no specific name. The man's gifts are simply called mpató "gift sent"; the woman's are called botúmo, a term used for all presents given by a woman to her lover (see also Chapter VI, Article VII, 2). The verb used with this noun is tumba, "to make burn." Etymologically the two words are in no way related.

431  
Gift Giving

584  
Arranging A Marriage

1. Note that for the Nkundó these expressions have quite a different significance than would appear from the words. They express a real agreement and an explicit and personal consent. In fact it is considered improper for a woman to use a more direct expression.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs: ✉ [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)